

Harmony

Harmony describes the relationship between different notes, whether they are played as part of a melody, or at the same time. If a melody is a line, harmony is the sequence of hooks on which it hangs.

SEE ALSO

◀ 64–67 Keys

◀ 80–85 Other scales

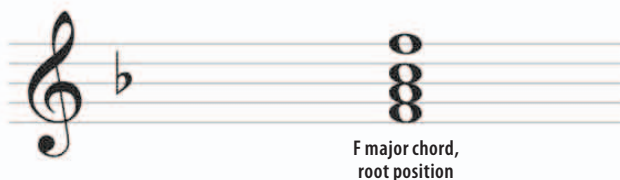
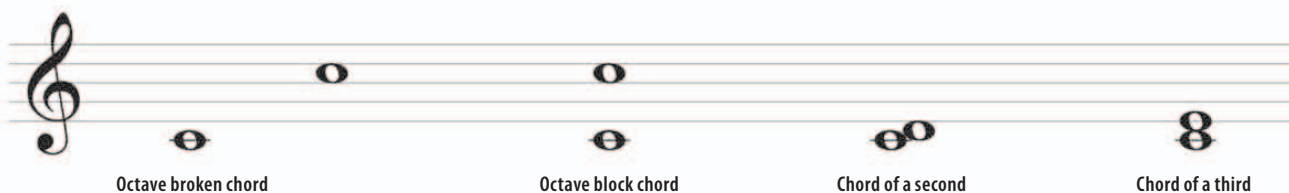
◀ 86–87 Modes

Consonance and dissonance 120–121 >

Musical textures 200–201 >

Chords

Notes played at the same time make a chord. Harmony describes the relationship between the notes of a chord, and each chord of a passage of music, such as a phrase. Chords are named after the root—the bottom note—and they are mostly based on triads, the various arrangements of the root and the stack of thirds above it.



◁ A simple chord

The key signature, with one flat, and bass note on F, tells us that this chord is in F major. Containing the root, the third, the fifth, and the octave, this is a chord of F major in root position. It is entirely consonant, which means it sounds harmonious and pleasing.

90

Harmonic series

Even single notes have a kind of harmony inside them, known as the harmonic series, or overtones. When you pluck a note on the string of a violin, guitar, harp, or any instrument from the string family, you hear not only the note that is played, but many overtones above that note.

91 ▽ Harmonic series

If you played this as a giant chord, it would sound strange and complicated, but all the notes belong to the C at the root.

